

Before Ellis Island: Castle Garden

From America's beginning, most immigrants came to the Promised Land by way of the port of New York. During the early 1800s, ships discharged hundreds of newcomers each day, unchecked and unregulated, at docks along Manhattan's notorious waterfront. Thugs and thieves, in what was to become a traditional welcome, pounced on the new arrivals as soon as the gang-planks went down.

By 1855 matters had gotten so out of hand that New York State leased Castle Garden, at the southern tip of Manhattan, for use as an immigration depot. The half-century-old circular structure, two hundred yards in circumference, had in its time served as a fort (Castle Clinton), a setting for band concerts, and a theater. Jenny Lind, "the Swedish Nightingale," had sung there in 1850, selling out the six-thousand-seat house for six performances. Castle Garden was the crowning jewel of Battery Park, a gracious promenade overlooking New York harbor.

Well-to-do residents of lower Manhattan were horrified by the notion of an immigrant landing-place in so elegant a setting. Battery Park, they predicted, would become a place of "riff-raff," and the glory would depart from Castle Garden. Their concerns proved prophetic.

In the early years of Castle Garden, immigrants arrived on small sailing ships, some aboard the same vessels that had carried black slaves from Africa. Their voyage took five or six weeks in cramped, filthy, disease-ridden quarters. For weeks after landing, the passengers

and their possessions reeked of "the smell of the ship"—described by one young Russian man as "a distillation of bilge and putrescence, impervious to the cleaning agents available to the poor."

Many would-be immigrants never reached their destination. The immigrant ship *Liebnitz*, from Hamburg, was forced by head winds to detour through the tropics. By the time it finally arrived in New York harbor in January 1868 after a fourteen-week voyage, 108 of the 544 passengers had died of typhoid fever. A young German girl, asked at dockside where her parents were, pointed to the ocean and said, "Down there."

After arriving ships anchored near Castle Garden, customs inspectors boarded the vessels and examined the baggage; then two 150-ton barges ferried the immigrants to the Castle Garden wharf. As many as three thousand newcomers a day streamed into the rotunda. Clerks registered the new arrivals in ledger books by name, nationality, former residence, and intended destination. Physicians gave them cursory inspections for disease. A labor bureau provided assistance in finding work. Each immigrant was given a jug of fresh water with which to bathe in twenty-foot-long troughs. Because there were no sleeping quarters, newcomers had to cart away their baggage before nightfall.

Under the protection of Castle Garden, so its commissioners claimed, immigrants were "enabled to depart for their future homes without having their means impaired, their morals corrupted, their persons diseased." Neverthe-

less, contingents of hardened con men, swindlers, and ladies of pleasure energetically plied their trades just outside the twelve-foot-high wooden fence that encircled the facility. Boarding-house "runners" steered the new arrivals to outrageously overpriced, run-down lodgings. Baggage handlers demanded drinking money—"trinkgelt"—if the newcomers wanted to see their belongings again.

Harper's Weekly, in 1858, painted this picture of the immigrant's plight: "Authorities regarded him as a bale of goods. Scoundrels seized him. If he had any money, they robbed him of it. If he had a pretty wife or daughters, they stole them too, if they could. If he had neither money nor wife nor daughters, they took his luggage. It was well for him if, after having been robbed of all he had, he was not beaten to death."

Immigrants who settled in the city found themselves trapped in tenement enclaves such as Hell's Kitchen, Bandits' Roost, and Thieves Alley—catch-basins of crime, filth, and disease. Many others, perhaps fortuitously, boarded trains for the open spaces westward.

New York officials connivingly looked the other way as the depredations of Castle Garden continued year after year.

Joseph Pulitzer's newspaper, the *World*, ran a series of scathing articles on Castle Garden in 1887, terming it "a place of unlawful detention, a place for tyranny and whimsical rule, a place for the abuse and insult of helpless women, for the inhuman treatment



Charles Frederic Ulrich's 1884 painting, "In the Land of Promise: Castle Garden," depicts immigrants awaiting registration in the immigrant depot's rotunda.

of mothers and children, for the privation of the poor, for the lecherous pursuit of shielded employees, for the disgrace of the nation in the eyes of those who desire to become citizens."

Conditions finally grew so deplorable that Congress held investigations of the depot. They found that the local inspectors couldn't keep up with the growing volumes of immigrants. Money-changers shortchanged the newcomers. Railroad agents gouged them on ticket prices. Runners fleeced them. Some immigrants were made to pay twice for their baggage. One agent matter-of-factly told investi-

gators, "We call Castle Garden 'Hell,' and don't expect to change Hell."

The federal government, dismayed by the nasty doings at Castle Garden, decided in 1890 to order its closure and take over from the states the inglorious business of admitting immigrants to America.

Some eight million people passed through Castle Garden during its thirty-five years as a reception depot—about seven in ten of all entering the United States during that period. Most were German (3,425,000), Irish (2,541,000), and English (1,178,000). Among the newcomers were future greats such as social reformer Jacob Riis (Denmark), physicist Michael Pupin (Serbia), labor organizer Samuel Gompers (England), and scientist Charles Steinmetz (Germany).

Castle Garden registered its last

immigrants on April 18, 1890. The big rotunda thereupon closed its doors.*

Just days before, President Benjamin Harrison had officially designated the site of the first—and destined to become the most famous—federal immigration station. Strollers near old Castle Garden could see the mud flat about a mile away, not far from the Statue of Liberty. It was small, it was low, and it was in water so shallow that no ship could land there.

Ellis Island. ★

**From 1896 to 1941, Castle Garden served as the New York City Aquarium. Then, after the structure sat vacant for more than thirty years, the U.S. National Park Service restored it to its original appearance as a War of 1812 fort. It is now operated by the Park Service in conjunction with Ellis Island and the Statue of Liberty.*